Reach

Ghost citations are 60.3% lower when the brand is in the title

AI SEO study across 71,275 AI citations

We looked at 71,275 AI citations of brands' own pages
4 engines: Google AI Mode, AI Overviews, ChatGPT, Perplexity
43 tracked brands · Jan 3 - Aug 21, 2026 (225 days)
Ghost rate = AI cites your page but doesn't name you
Within-brand: fewer ghosts in 17 of 20 brands (p = 0.003)

Source: Reach AI-search data, 4 engines, Jan 3-Aug 21 2026, n = 71,275 page citations



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What we *studied*

Reach AI-search tracking data, 4 AI engines

1

71,275 page citations, 43 tracked brands

AI answers citing exactly one of a brand's own pages. Observational: correlation, not a controlled test.

2

Ghost rate = unnamed / all citations

A ghost citation links to the brand's page, but the answer doesn't name the brand (Reach extraction flag).

3

Brand in title = name in page title

Word-bounded match on the page or meta title in Reach's page snapshot.

4

3 questions: title, intro or body text

Is the brand name in the page title? In the first ~500 characters? How often in the page text (0, 1-2, 3-9, 10+)?

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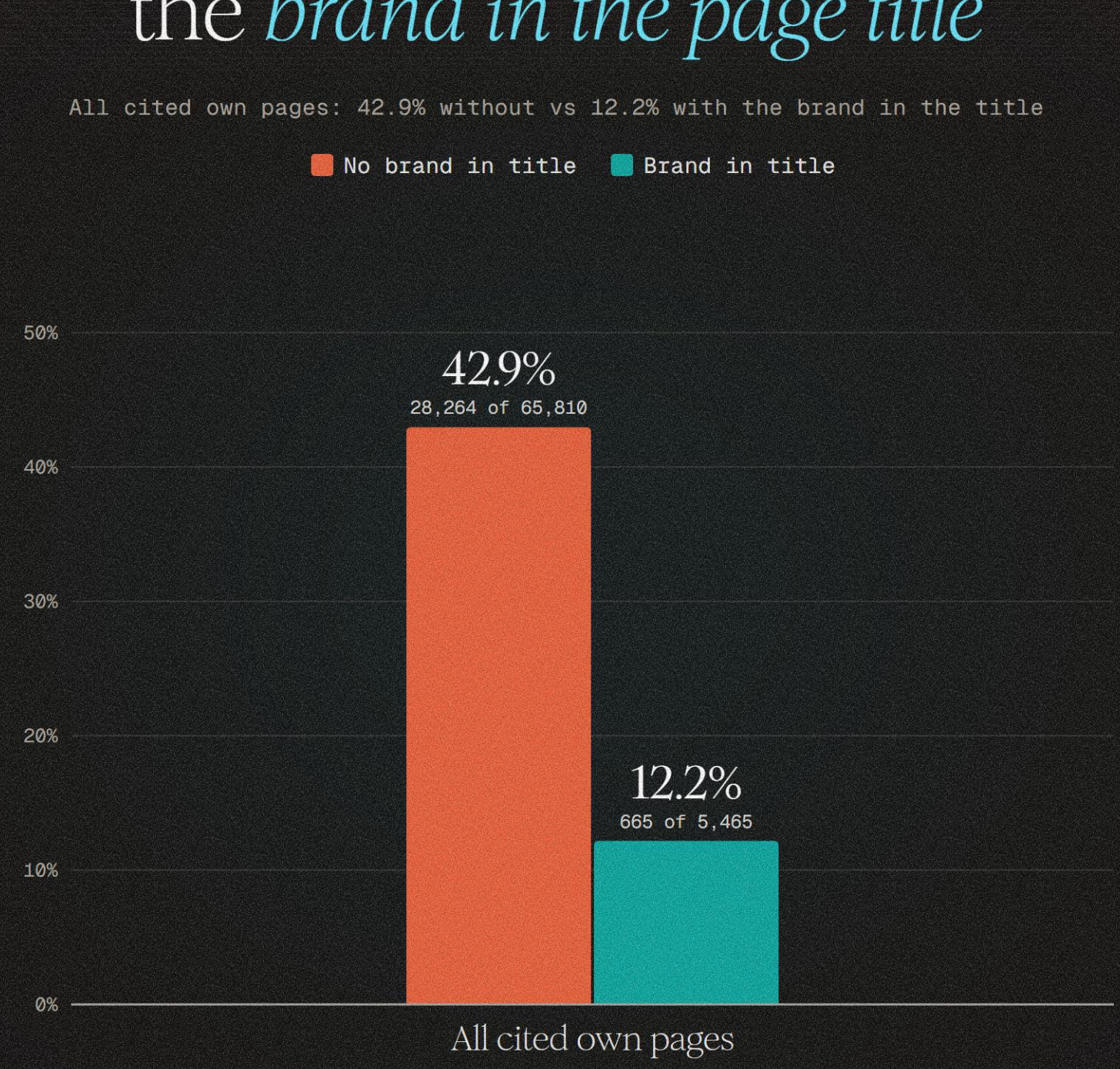
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Ghost rate without vs with the *brand in the page title*

All cited own pages: 42.9% without vs 12.2% with the brand in the title



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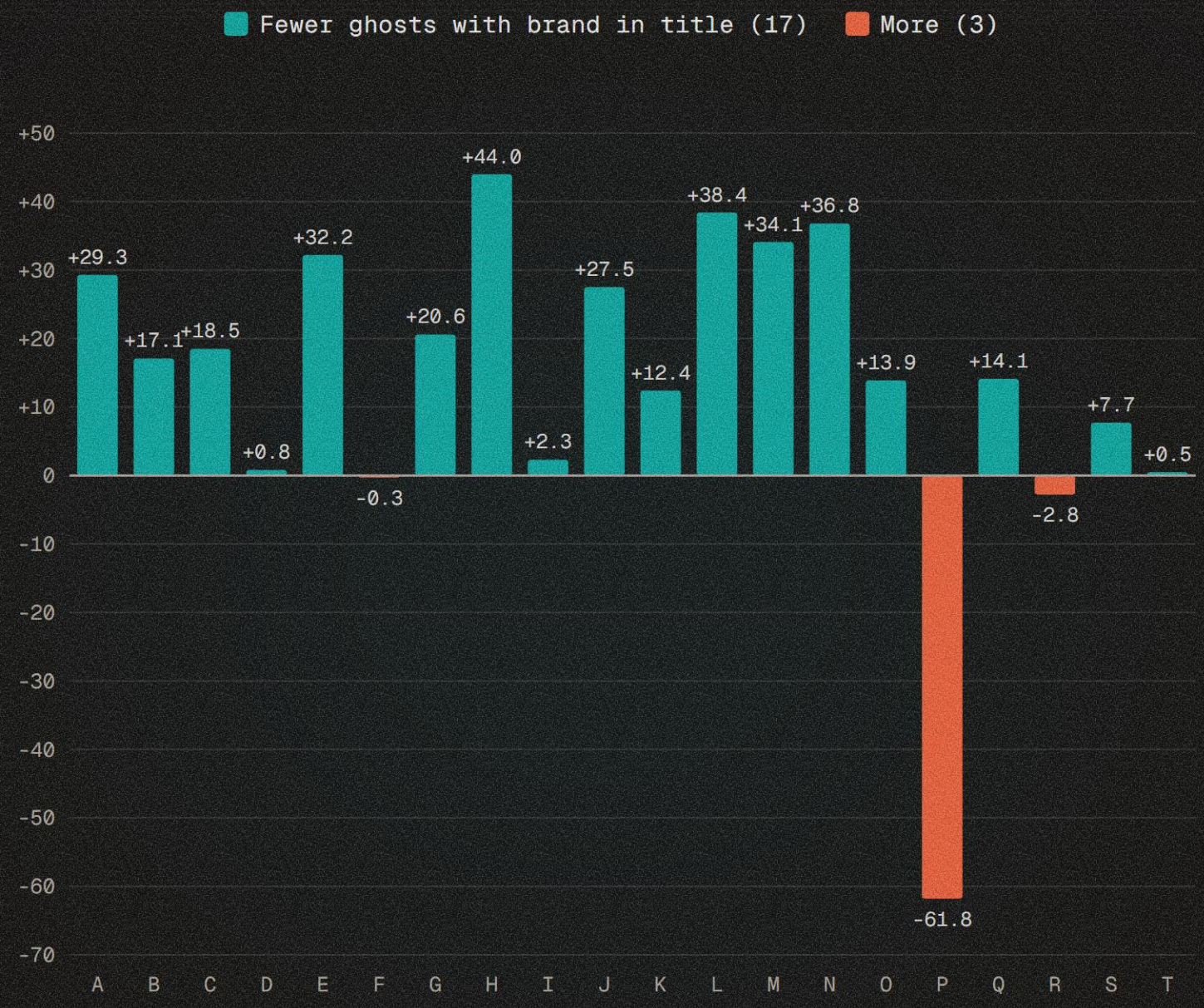
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Ghost rate *gap* per brand

Each bar = one brand: ghost rate without minus with its name in the title (pts)



Orange = more ghosts with brand in title. Brand P: only 18 brand-titled citations

Within-brand: 60.3% lower (Mantel-Haenszel), p = 0.003. 20 brands, 10+ each; n = 36,400



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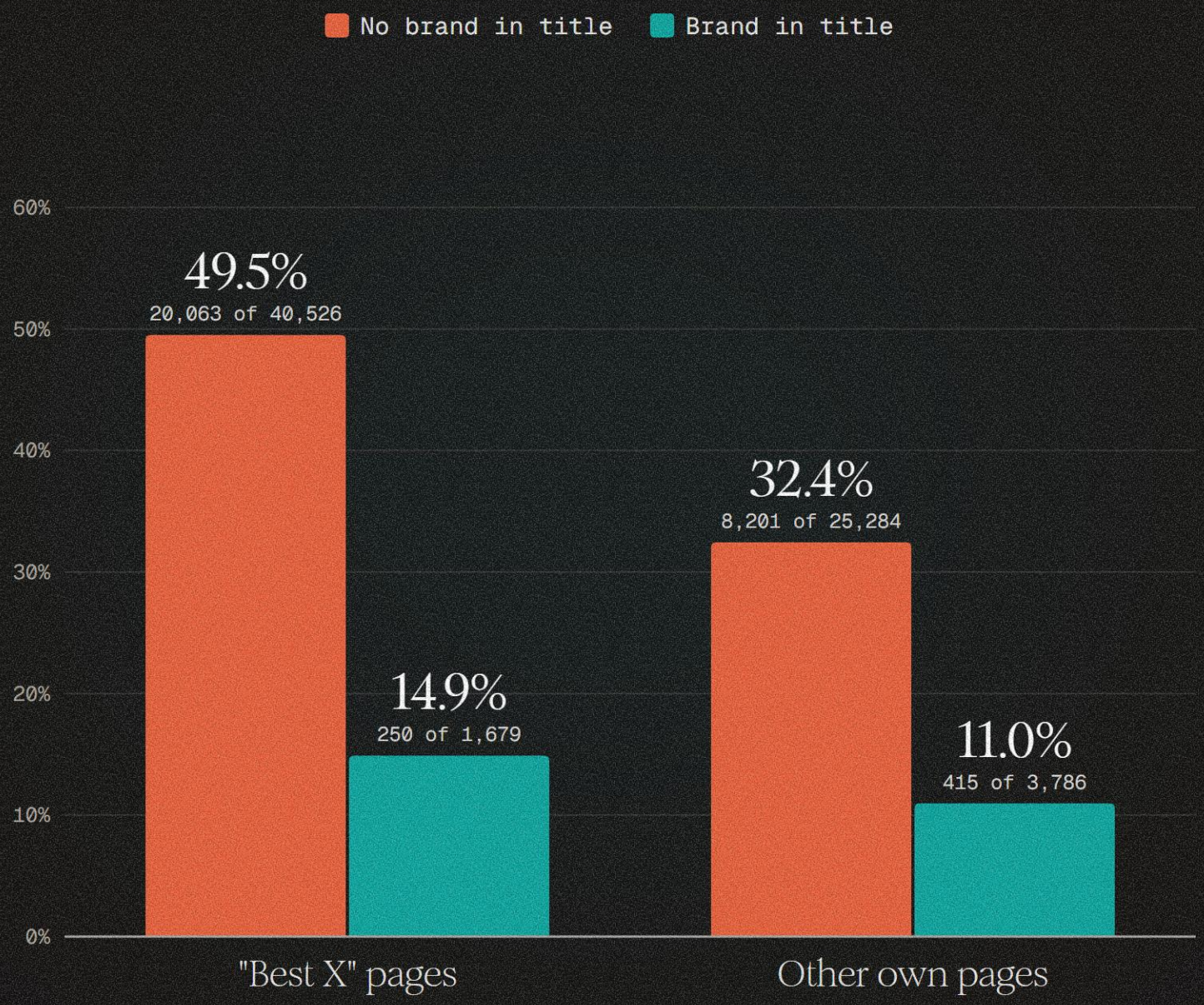
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Ghost rate by *page type* without vs with brand in title

"Best X" pages ghosted most (49.5%); within-brand evidence thin (5 brands)



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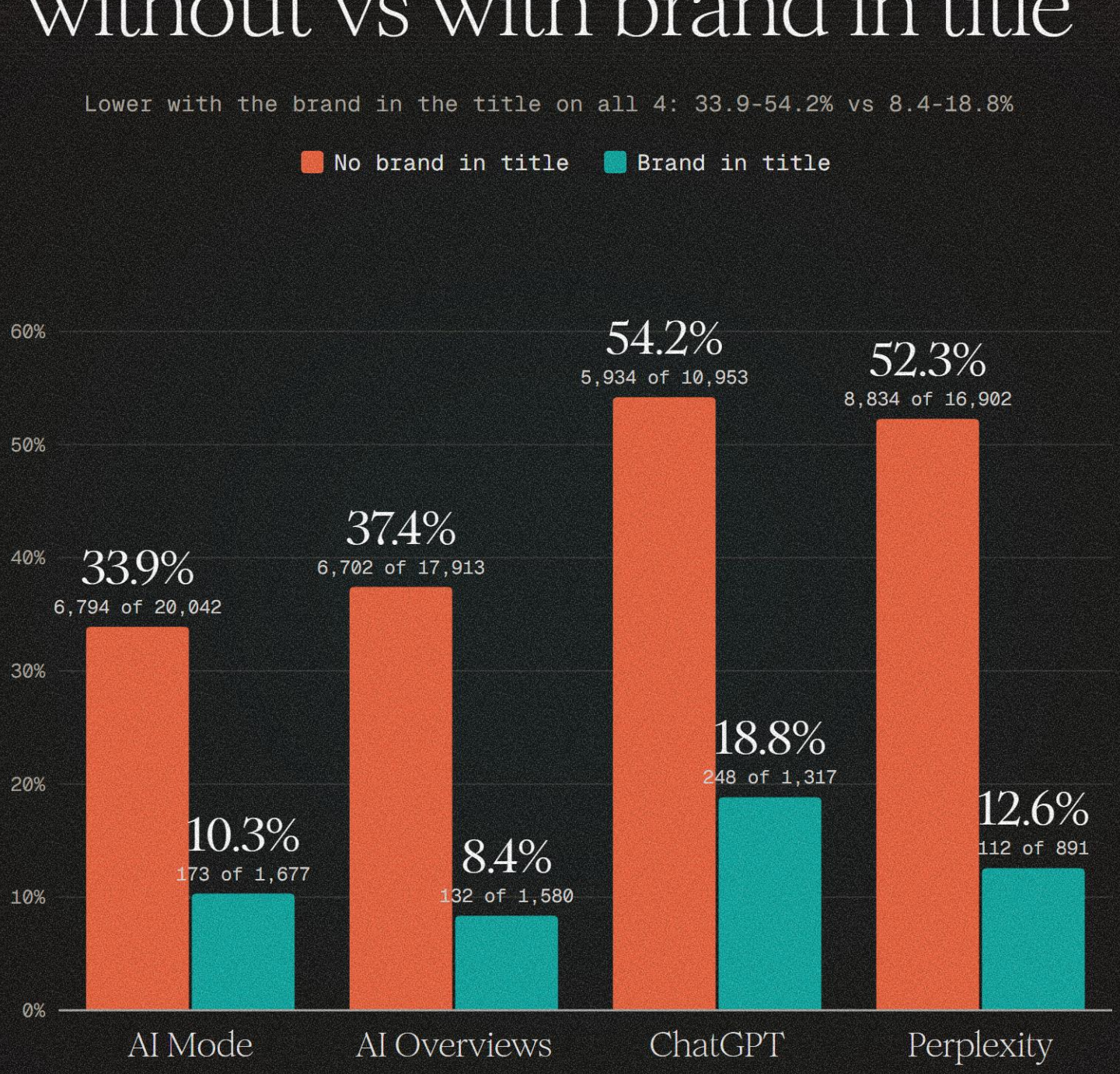
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Ghost rate by *AI engine* without vs with brand in title

Lower with the brand in the title on all 4: 33.9-54.2% vs 8.4-18.8%



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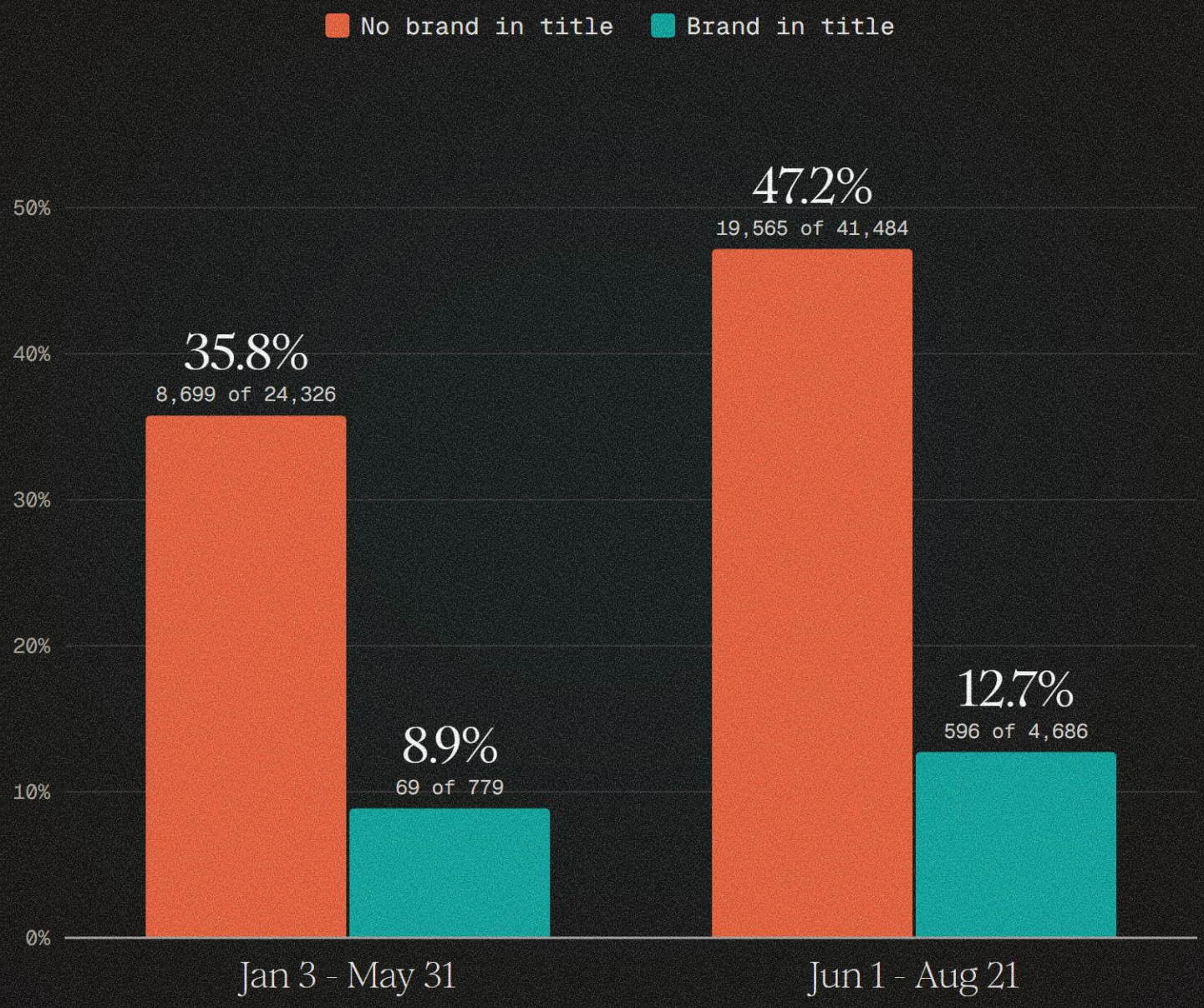
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Ghost rate by *time period* without vs with brand in title

Jan-May: 35.8% vs 8.9%. Jun-Aug: 47.2% vs 12.7%. Same pattern in both



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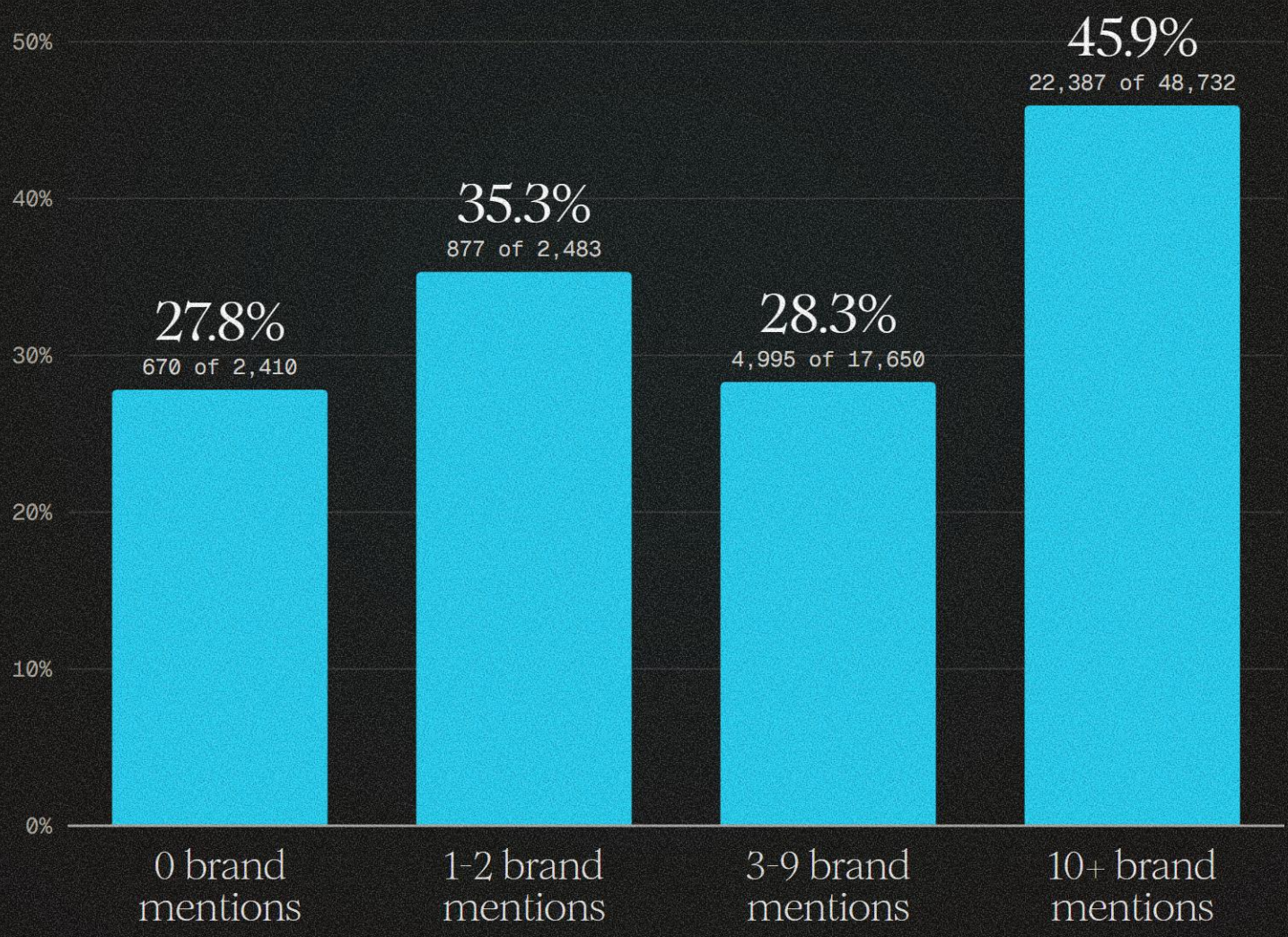
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Ghost rate by number of *brand mentions* on the page

Counts include menus and footers, so 10+ may reflect site chrome, not content



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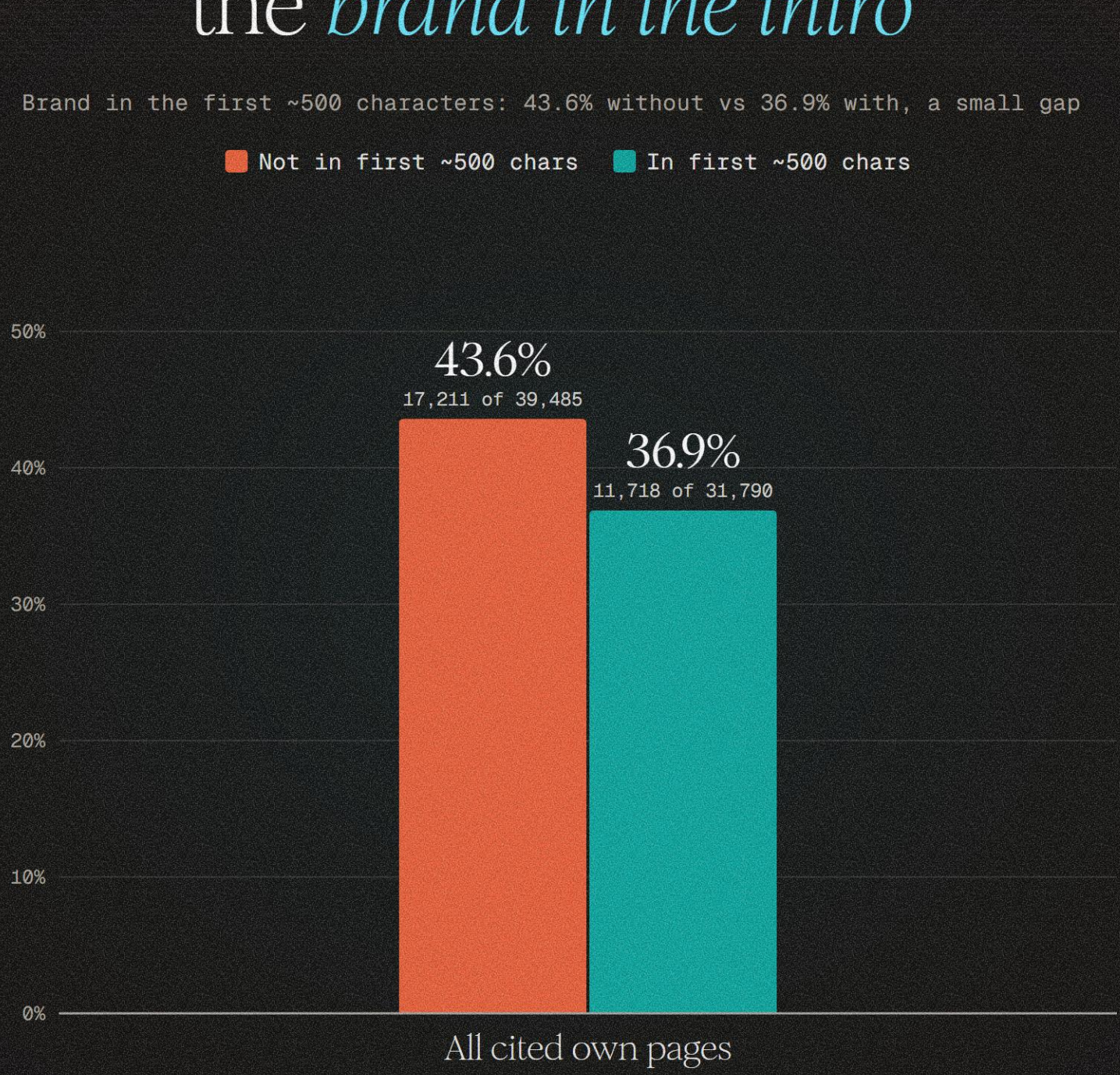
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Ghost rate without vs with the *brand in the intro*

Brand in the first ~500 characters: 43.6% without vs 36.9% with, a small gap



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What it *means*

What we saw, and what we think explains it

WHAT WE SAW

The title matters most

Brand in title: 12.2% ghosted, vs 42.9% without

Same brand: 60.3% lower

True in 17 of 20 brands and on all 4 engines

WHAT WE THINK

Source, not endorsement

“Best X” pages: 49.5% ghosted, the highest

AI may trust your list as a source, but not your own entry in it

Not yet proven (5 brands)

WHAT WE THINK

Where beats how often

10+ mentions: 45.9% ghosted, the highest

Name in intro: small gap (36.9% vs 43.6%)

Placement may matter more than repetition

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What to *do*

Each action maps to a finding in this deck

1 Add your brand to cited page titles

Start with pages AI already cites: 42.9% ghosted without the brand in the title vs 12.2% with it.

2 Start with “best X” and comparison pages

They’re ghosted most often (49.5%). Within-brand evidence is thin, so change titles and measure.

3 Name the brand early, not often

Brand in the first ~500 characters: 36.9% vs 43.6%. Pages with 10+ mentions: 45.9%.

4 Track ghost rate per page monthly

Ghost rate = citations that don't name you / all citations of your page.

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Is AI *ghosting* your brand?

Comment *GHOST* below

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